

Live & editable. This site was adopted at the 11 Aug 2026 working session as the group’s shared coordination tool — Damien Conrad (Felix Project) directs the content, Dark Matter Labs keeps it updated.

Updated 11 August 2026

A working group note from London, 2026.

Hubs and Markets Working Group

Hub managers, boroughs, the GLA’s markets team and the organisations already redistributing food across the city sit down together — so the next borough starting a hub inherits what the last four learned, instead of starting from a blank page.

[Open the hub documentation ↗](#)

[Who’s in the room](#)

[Open the wider portfolio](#)

4+

Live or forming hubs compared

260T

Food moved through Lambeth’s hub / yr

~90

Food projects across Camden + Islington alone

2030–31

New Billingsgate & Smithfield opens, Royal Docks

Why the room exists

One table, three constituencies

The working group exists to connect London’s food hub managers, the boroughs still trying to build one, and the GLA’s London Markets team — and to turn what any one of them has learned into something the whole city can use.

The stated objective is plain: bring together hub managers, boroughs exploring the opportunity, and the GLA’s markets planning team to **share what’s already been learned**, name the challenges every hub hits in common, and find the openings to build hubs that can genuinely receive food at bulk and sort it out again to many downstream partners.

The prize on the table is larger than logistics. Surplus redistribution is the easy entry point, but the group keeps returning to a longer list — the inequity built into how food moves through the city, malnutrition, and climate risk to supply — with food positioned not as the end point, but as the catalyst that lets local food projects work on the causes of poverty, not just its symptoms.

Who’s around the table

Felix Project	Community Coordination, Partnerships
GLA	Economic Development & Markets Relocation, Sustainability
Healthy Living Platform	Lambeth Food Hub
Manor Gardens / Islington Food Partnership	also East Sussex Public Health, Local Food Plan
Newham Council	Food Hub & Newham Food Alliance
Hackney CVS	Hackney Food Network and Public Health, Hackney
Bow Food Bank	Tower Hamlets Food Poverty Network
Sustain	London Food Board, Bridging the Gap
Camden Council	Food Team, Regis Road site

Four hubs, one anatomy

Same four layers. Four different ways to survive.

Aggregation, storage, logistics and purchasing show up in every hub the group has compared. What changes borough to borough is who pays for which layer, and what breaks first when the money gets tight. Pick a hub below.

Lambeth (HLP)

Newham (council-run)

Tower Hamlets

Camden + Islington

Governance and relationship management

Aggregation

Pooling produce & surplus into volumes one supplier alone couldn't offer

Storage

Chilled / frozen / dry, held for crisis

Logistics

Moving food out, on schedule

Purchasing and cost recovery

Who pays: Cost+, Cost, Pay, or nothing at all

Lambeth Healthy Living Platform

260T food / year

46 groups + 3 social supermarkets

Long lease, free tenure

Sited in a converted car park, HLP reaches downstream groups Felix and City Harvest can't reach on their own — 50% of Felix's Lambeth-borough food now moves through this one hub. A food-ambassador programme, an employability scheme and recipe boxes sit alongside it.

The social supermarket model returns roughly £14 of food value for every £4 spent — a genuinely strong ratio undermined by a structural problem: HLP lost council funding just as demand kept growing.

Where it breaks: the traded-income model closed for lack of funding. HLP has a lottery bid in for £480k over 3 years and leans heavily on corporate giving to bridge the gap —

funding for a discrete project is easier to find than funding for business-as-usual.

Also in the room

Barking & Dagenham

A newer hub, currently redistributing surplus, with a stated desire to do more — one step behind the boroughs above on the same path.

Cited as the benchmark

Surplus2Supper

Runs events, catering and cooked meals alongside redistribution — reaching thousands across south-west London and into Surrey. Flagged by attendees as the most sustainable model in the room.

Study visit

Birmingham

A circular, sustainable hub built on collective purchasing with direct links to local farms and wholesalers — earmarked for a group visit.

Felix Project and the logistics reality

Two kinds of surplus, and a funding gap in between

Felix Project's own depot network is the clearest illustration of why hub-and-spoke geography matters — and of the gap between what the current system can absorb and what's actually going to waste.

The UK's food system holds roughly **72 hours of stock** at any one time — everything from manufacturing through wholesale to retail runs just-in-time. That's a deliberate design choice for cost, and it means the surplus Felix Project handles is two different problems wearing the same name: food made surplus by a *manufacturing or retail*

hiccup, and food left on farms by a genuine system failure — a contract cancelled, a spec too strict, a crop that outgrew its harvest window.

4 Felix depots inside London, plus roughly 32 more across the wider network

Arctic → transit Food arrives on large trucks, leaves on smaller ones — the further a depot sits from the frontline that needs it, the longer that last mile gets

Declined Felix was asked to run the new Barking & Dagenham hub this year and said no — already stretched thin merging with FareShare

“The purple sprouting was five foot tall and bolted in the heat — you were only touching the sides. Everything else got ploughed back in that night.”

On a gleaning day, purple sprouting broccoli, Kent

An estimated **2.9m tonnes** of edible surplus produce is wasted on UK farms each year, but only 1-2% is redistributed via charity channels. That’s enough for 6.9 billion meals — enough to feed 18 million people a meal a day. Economic hurdles and a lack of infrastructure often make it cheaper for growers to plough surplus crops straight back into the earth, send them to anaerobic digestion, or use them as animal feed, rather than pay to harvest and redistribute them. Getting substantially more of that food off the fields is, by Felix’s own estimate, an £8-10m infrastructure question, not a strategy question.

1-2%

Of the 2.9m tonnes of edible farm surplus that reaches people through charity

£8-10m

Estimated to move meaningfully beyond that

Almost no organisation is running this logistics model at scale — Street Box (with Juniper, in Newham) is doing a smaller version, and City Harvest is the only comparable operator. Which is exactly why the group keeps returning to hub-and-spoke: the closer the final depot sits to the frontline, the shorter — and cheaper — that last mile becomes.

The tension underneath it: Felix Project's mission is surplus redistribution, not farm-level systems change — but food and social justice are already the leverage getting hubs built. Closing that gap, deliberately, is part of what this working group exists to hold.

Reference diagrams from The Felix Project

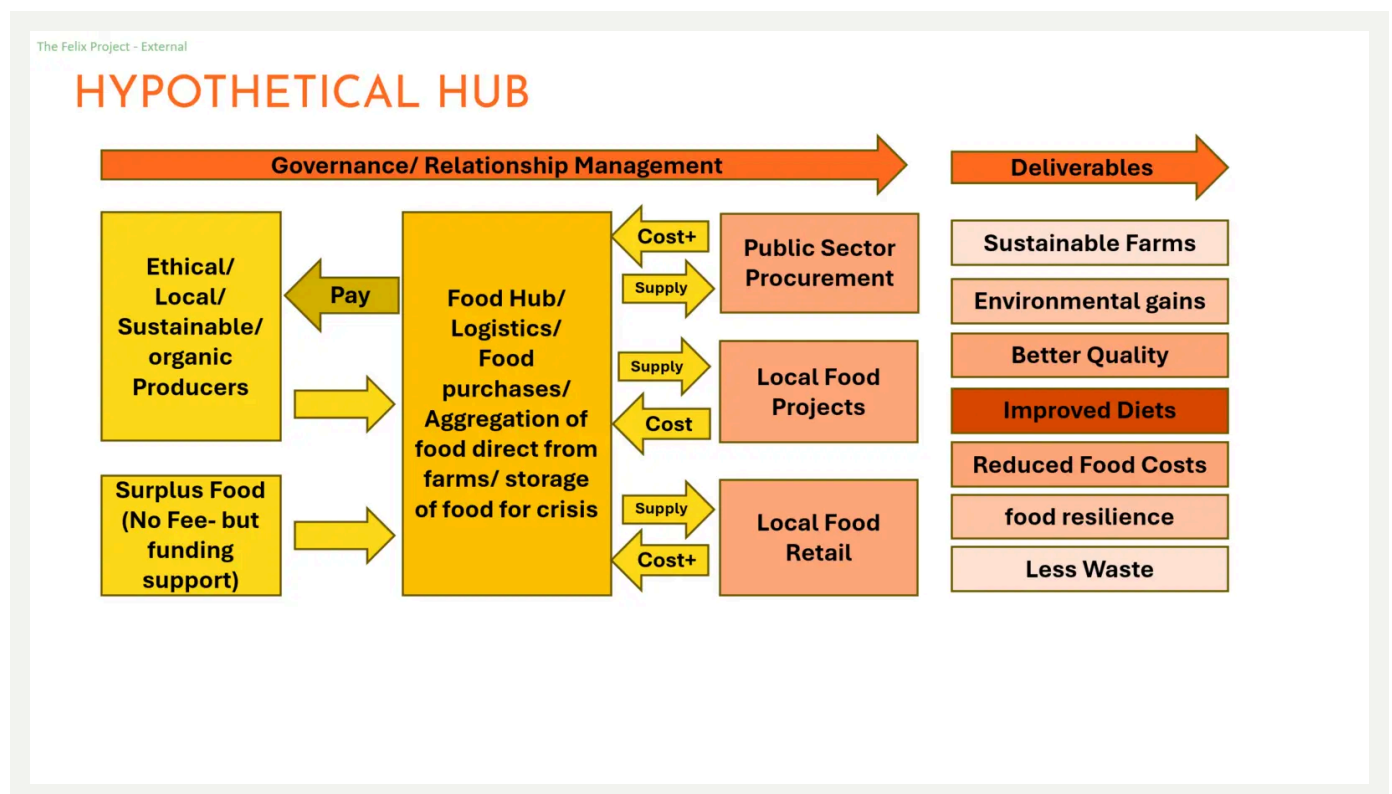
What a hub actually does, drawn out

Three ways of looking at the same machine — the flows of money and food through a hub, the same anatomy exploded out across boroughs, and the closed loop a hub makes possible once nothing has to go to waste.

Hypothetical hub

Cross-borough, exploded

Closed-loop system



The money follows the food, not the other way round

Producers get paid. Surplus donors pay nothing — the hub absorbs that logistics cost so surplus stays genuinely free at the point of donation. Downstream, procurement and retail pay cost-plus; food projects pay cost, or less, because a funded relationship is what keeps them alive, not a market one.

Why this page shows three, not one

Every hub the group compared runs some version of aggregation, storage, logistics and purchasing — but which layer is funded, and which is starved, is exactly where Lambeth, Newham, Tower Hamlets and Camden + Islington diverge. The diagram above is the shared skeleton this page keeps returning to.

Billingsgate, Smithfield & the Royal Docks

The wholesale layer is moving too

While hub managers compare notes at community scale, London's two historic wholesale markets are being rebuilt at city scale a few miles downriver — and the GLA is deliberately opening the door for the two conversations to meet.

The move

The City of London Corporation is relinquishing responsibility for Billingsgate and Smithfield. The GLA is developing the freehold at Royal Docks, with new combined markets planned for Albert Island in **2030-31**, bringing an estimated **7,000-12,000 jobs** to one of London's most deprived areas.

Beyond B2B

Working with Claire Pritchard at GCDA, the plan explores co-located services — a Food Academy teaching entry-level hospitality skills, an employment accelerator with food traders and restaurants, and a shift from a pure business-to-business model toward genuine business-to-consumer access, including a community café.

Hub and spoke

The markets team is also exploring logistics and infrastructure on a hub-and-spoke model with satellite sites — the same shape the community food hubs are converging on independently, at a different scale. The team's related circular-construction work is visible at tippingpointeast.com ↗.

Now	Freehold in development — GLA leading at Royal Docks, Albert Island site.
In progress	Food Academy & accelerator design with GCDA — entry-level hospitality skills, trader employment.
Exploring	B2C shift — a community café, and public access to a market historically built for trade buyers only.
2030-31	New Billingsgate & Smithfield open on Albert Island, alongside 7,000-12,000 new jobs.

Building the case

The coalition that makes one bid instead of 32

The working group's own logic — coordinate instead of duplicate — is now the explicit strategy for the funding and policy bids sitting behind it.

Convening the network

Felix Project

Felix Project has been working with at least ten boroughs already building a hub or exploring the possibility, coordinating this working group so best practice gets shared — and, with many boroughs considering stand-alone Climate Action Fund lottery bids, encouraging collaborative working on food systems instead of 32 separate applications.

Building the funding case

Sustain

That coordination has culminated in Sustain building a consortium and sharing their National Lottery bid with boroughs, asking for expressions of interest — a single partnership bid tested across several hubs at once, rather than each borough bidding alone.

The wider portfolio

Dark Matter Labs

Focused on the broader picture of London's collective buying power — not only hubs and civic infrastructure, but also larger procurement and business purchases — and building a wider portfolio of work around that focus, of which this working group is one part.

National lever

Oxford (Paul Behrens's team)

Oxford's policy briefings are read inside government. Positioning that team as the national-influence channel means the ground-level evidence this group generates has somewhere credible to land. Paul Behrens is also a member of the National Emergency Briefing team.

Health & climate angle

Hugh Montgomery / Adrien Burn

Hugh Montgomery — an ICU surgeon who reported to the UK's COVID inquiry that obesity was a major factor in who died, and who sits on UN and UK climate panels — is already delivering national emergency briefings on food and health together. Adrien Burn, at Real Zero Earth, runs his office and is the practical point of contact.

Dark Matter Labs runs an open-IP policy. Everything produced gets published immediately — no hoarding, no gatekeeping blueprints behind a conference contact list. If a flagship borough works out how to do something (Tower Hamlets' HFSS advertising ban, for instance, and the revenue objections it overcame on the way), the plan is for that roadmap to live on a public server, not travel by word of mouth.

Where London's 32 boroughs sit today



■ Flagship, pushing food + climate together (Camden among them)

■ Right intentions, still climbing the learning curve

■ Under-resourced or under-ambition

The pattern under every hub

Everyone can fund the capex. No one can fund the boring part.

Strip away the borough-specific detail and the same six constraints recur in every hub story the group has compared.

Capex is fundable. Working capital and BAU are not. ×

Every borough in the room has successfully raised capital funding for a hub building or fit-out. What consistently doesn't attract funding is the unglamorous layer underneath it — the working capital to buy food ahead of being paid for it, and the ongoing cost of simply keeping the doors open. Funders will back a project; almost none will back business-as-usual.

Social value is real, and almost impossible to price. +

Boroughs are competing for the same climate money, alone. +

The infrastructure has to be built now, not after the next shock. +

“Truly surplus” rules stop a hub intervening early enough to help. +

Getting incentives wrong can pay a farmer to stop farming. +

Cross-checked against a peer network, not invented here

What a conversation outside this group confirmed, and what it added

A recent conversation with a national network supporting independent, values-led food traders and wholesalers — plus a council food-mission partnerships lead already working alongside this group — surfaced patterns that either confirm what this working group has already found, or add a genuinely new angle worth holding onto. Names and organisations are deliberately left out below; the Camden food hub is named because its own detail is the point.

Who actually pays for hub space is worth stating plainly.

×

At the Camden food hub, the commercial organic wholesaler running it pays real rent for its unit — cheaper than its previous site, but rent nonetheless — while the surplus-redistribution partner pays nothing for space. That isn't preferential treatment either way; it's a landlord charging a below-market commercial rate to one tenant and none to the other. But it surfaces an asymmetry every future hub will hit: redistribution charities already draw significant public funding; organic wholesalers currently draw close to none. Whether that gap is fair, or worth correcting, is a decision worth making on purpose rather than by default.

A small collective-buying pilot came back with real numbers attached.

+

“Surplus” often means cosmetically rejected, not close to spoiling — and that creates a real ethical trade-off.

+

A hub may not have to choose between organic supply and surplus redistribution.

+

Short contract cycles are an underused lever, not just a constraint.

+

Hub failure risk sits in operating skillset, not good intentions.

+

Beneficiary criteria can raise standards, not just distribute food. +

External research already under way is worth connecting with, not duplicating. +

Net takeaway: none of this contradicts what the group has already found in its own boroughs — if anything, hearing the same patterns independently from outside the room is a useful cross-check. The genuinely new material is the collective-buying savings data, the both-markets hub design question, and the short-cycle contract lever — all three are concrete enough to act on before the next meeting.

Draft notes from the second cross-network meeting, not yet reviewed.

Birmingham, Sustain and the wider network

A second, larger working-group session brought in a live Birmingham hub, Sustain's national procurement work, and Dark Matter Labs' wider framing, then opened to questions from across the room. Drafted straight from the meeting — dates, names and figures below are flagged where they need checking before this counts as final.

A live Birmingham hub, running on a shoestring, already moving real volume. ×

Vicki, from a Birmingham community wellbeing charity, presented a hub built inside a wholesale market: roughly 150 sq m of warehouse space plus a purpose-built commercial kitchen, reached after the council's public health team approached the charity directly about building community resilience. Public health funding covered the initial build, including the kitchen; the council now covers around half of running costs. Surplus from market traders either feeds the kitchen for meals or goes straight out through a redistribution network similar to London's. Scale is still small and pilot-stage — around 8 tonnes redistributed in the most recent month, reaching four towns — but cumulative impact stands at roughly 70,000 portions of food redistributed to date.

Funding is confirmed only until March, which the presenter named directly as the binding constraint, not appetite or demand — set against Birmingham's child poverty rate, cited in the room as close to 46%.

A same-day growing pilot showed what a genuinely short supply chain looks like. +

Collective buying is already working at hub level, not just in theory. +

Sustain is scoping a place-based collective-purchasing bid — and named what funders won't fund. +

A London-wide food resilience partnership is being set up, inside London Resilience. +

Dark Matter Labs framed the funding ask around the cost of two compounding shocks. +

"We speak different languages" is a real Q&A theme, with a proposed answer. +

Why hubs have to sit close to the frontline, in Felix Project's own words. +

What's next, from this meeting: a survey is going out to the working group to help map members into smaller, more agile sub-groups by shared issue or borough cluster, rather than running everything through one large meeting.

Needs checking before this is final: the Birmingham presenter's organisation name (heard as something close to "Active Wellbeing Society" on a difficult recording), the exact scale figures (8 tonnes/month, 70,000 portions to date, ~46% child poverty), and the Food Foundation retailer-coalition campaign and its reported £500m demand-side figure, referenced in passing but not the meeting's main subject.

Where this sits

The evidence base under the Hub track

This working group isn't a side conversation to the wider Food as Infrastructure portfolio — it's where the "Hub" track gets tested against real boroughs, real leases and real funding gaps, before any of it is asked to scale.

Track

Hub

Public-interest grocers, multi-ledger ownership and a collective buying engine only mean anything once a hub has actually solved aggregation, storage, logistics and cost recovery — which is exactly what Lambeth, Newham, Tower Hamlets and Camden + Islington are living through right now.

Governance, tier 2

A coalition of boroughs

The portfolio's Tier 2 ambition — Camden's neighbouring boroughs sharing standards and collective buying rather than repeating from zero — is this working group's actual agenda, several boroughs early.

Demand

Procurement protocol

Newham and Tower Hamlets are both already trying to buy more collectively and more ethically — the exact behaviour a shared procurement protocol is built to make easier, and cheaper, to do.

[See the full Supply / Hub / Demand portfolio](#)

Beyond the next funding round

Five years, not 2040

2040 is far enough away to feel safe to ignore. The group's next exercise picks a nearer horizon on purpose: what would a system look like that we'd be proud to hand to our grandchildren — and what has to be true in five years for that to still be on track?

The question on the table

How are people fed. What are they eating, and how does it reach them. How far have London's large supermarkets moved away from the practices that currently degrade the food system. And — put to Felix Project directly — could an organisation built on redistributing surplus eventually evolve into a piece of state-owned food infrastructure, rather than a permanent workaround for one that's failing.

Two working precedents

Brazil — under Lula's government, state-run hub-and-spoke logistics connect farms directly to public plates, with the state carrying the logistics risk rather than each supplier bearing it alone.

Sweden — a small municipality has piloted “preparedness procurement,” where local farmers become de facto stewards of resilience: growing grains and legumes for municipal storage that doubles as a hub feeding public-sector kitchens.

The ask

Damien Conrad to sketch what “great” looks like for Felix Project and the wider system — the same diagramming instinct already behind the hub diagrams on this page, pointed five years out instead of at the current state.

Follow-up call to be scheduled

Work ahead from the working group and the 11 August review

What happens next, and who's doing it

Two sets of follow-ups sit behind this page: the working group's own reports-and-follow-ups list, and the concrete actions agreed when this site was reviewed with Felix Project on 11 August.

Damien Conrad Felix Project, owner of the content on this page

- | | | |
|-------|--|-----------------|
| 01 | Review the development version of the wider Food as Infrastructure frame and send back a first round of edits. | Awaiting review |
| <hr/> | | |
| 02 | Keep this page's content accurate — this site is now Damien's to direct; changes go back to Dark Matter Labs to publish. | Ongoing |
| <hr/> | | |
| 03 | Share the councils' resource file — the shared folder of funded hub proposals, capacity models (feed X people from Y supply, embedded carbon, go-live implementation plans) — so it can sit alongside this page for every council in dialogue. | In progress |
| <hr/> | | |
| 04 | Sketch what a genuinely good food system looks like in five years — the Horizon exercise above. | Scoped |
| <hr/> | | |

Dark Matter Labs Adam Purvis & team, who build and maintain both sites

- | | | |
|-------|---|-------------|
| 05 | Publish both sites — the wider portfolio frame and this working-group page — and make sure Damien can share this one immediately. | Live |
| <hr/> | | |
| 06 | Rework the hub diagram into the cleaner version already in progress, and fold in any other edits Damien sends. | In progress |

07	Contact Adrien Burn at Real Zero Earth to open a direct line to Hugh Montgomery's office on the health-and-food angle for the national emergency briefings.	To do
08	Share the Oxford + GLA crisis resilience report 7 from the pandemic era across the group.	To circulate

The working group Boroughs, hub managers, GLA markets team

09	Move boroughs off separate climate-funding bids and onto one collective application, led by Sustain — Newham excepted, running its own.	In discussion
10	Zoning food-support conversations with the interested boroughs: Hackney, Waltham Forest, Tower Hamlets, Camden.	Open
11	Organise a group visit to Birmingham's circular hub — collective purchasing, direct farm and wholesaler links.	Planned
12	Link the group into a farmers' meeting in East Sussex.	Scheduled
13	Schedule the follow-up call to keep refining this project's goals and the five-year vision together.	To schedule
14	Keep the working group meeting bi-monthly.	Standing
15	Hackney is the newest borough working through this — see where they are and what's next , checked directly against the findings above.	New
16	The Camden + Islington hub — the same one above — is now recruiting an operator. See Islington's side of it , including a new finding worth watching: running one hub across two differently-structured borough partnerships.	New

London Hubs & Markets

A working group supported by Dark Matter Labs' Food as Infrastructure portfolio, grown out of the Camden Food Mission and the Camden Food Partnership, meeting bi-monthly with hub managers, boroughs and the GLA's markets team.

This page

Who's in the room
Hub anatomy
Systems diagrams
Wholesale markets
Shared constraint
Learning from outside
2nd meeting (draft)
Next steps

Wider portfolio

Food as Infrastructure
Hackney: overview
Hackney: what's next
Islington: overview
Islington: what's next
Negative Portfolio NP 2.0 ↗
Live Camden map ↗

Source: London Hubs & Markets Working Group notes, 2026, and the review session between Damien Conrad and Dark Matter Labs, 11 August 2026. Reference diagrams courtesy of The Felix Project. A working draft from Dark Matter Labs' Food as Infrastructure portfolio.

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